

ADHD MORNING ROUTINE PLANNER

Stop the Chaos, Start Your Day Right

Practical Systems for Adults with ADHD
Who Struggle with Mornings

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WHY MORNINGS ARE HARD WITH ADHD

If mornings feel like your personal nemesis, you're not lazy.

ADHD brains have specific challenges that make mornings harder:

1. **SLEEP INERTIA:** ADHD brains take longer to 'boot up'
Your prefrontal cortex (planning/decision brain) is sluggish
2. **TIME BLINDNESS:** You genuinely don't feel time passing
'5 more minutes' turns into 45 without you noticing
3. **DECISION FATIGUE:** Every choice costs more mental energy
What to wear, what to eat, what to bring = overwhelming
4. **TRANSITION DIFFICULTY:** Switching from sleep to action is HARD
Your brain resists changing states (this is neurological, not moral)
5. **WORKING MEMORY ISSUES:** You forget steps mid-routine
Start brushing teeth, get distracted, forget breakfast
6. **DOPAMINE DEFICIT:** Routine tasks produce zero dopamine
Your brain screams 'BORING' and seeks stimulation instead

THE GOOD NEWS:

You don't need more willpower. You need better SYSTEMS.

This planner gives you external structure so your brain doesn't have to work so hard. Let the system do the thinking.

THE 3-ANCHOR SYSTEM

Instead of a complex morning routine, build around 3 ANCHORS.

Anchors are non-negotiable actions that everything else attaches to.

ANCHOR 1: THE WAKE-UP ANCHOR

This is what pulls you out of bed. Choose ONE:

- ☐ Alarm across the room (must physically get up)
- ☐ Light therapy lamp on timer
- ☐ Phone alarm in bathroom
- ☐ Coffee maker on auto-timer (smell gets you up)
- ☐ Accountability partner texts/calls

My wake-up anchor: _____

ANCHOR 2: THE BODY ANCHOR

This 'turns on' your body and brain. Choose ONE:

- ☐ Splash cold water on face immediately
- ☐ 2-minute stretch routine (same every day)
- ☐ Step outside for 60 seconds of sunlight
- ☐ Quick shower (no decisions - same temp, same products)
- ☐ 10 jumping jacks right out of bed

My body anchor: _____

ANCHOR 3: THE LAUNCH ANCHOR

This is your 'out the door' signal. Choose ONE:

- ☐ Grab launch pad bag (pre-packed night before)
- ☐ Set 'leaving NOW' alarm 5 min before deadline
- ☐ Keys + phone + wallet checkpoint at door
- ☐ Partner/roommate 5-minute warning

My launch anchor: _____

RULE: Do your 3 anchors in ORDER, every single day.

Everything else can flex. The anchors don't.

VISUAL ROUTINE BUILDER

Build YOUR custom morning sequence

List ONLY essential tasks. Less is more with ADHD. Aim for 5-8 steps max.

MY MORNING ROUTINE (in order):

Step 1: Task: _____ Time needed: ____ min

Step 2: Task: _____ Time needed: ____ min

Step 3: Task: _____ Time needed: ____ min

Step 4: Task: _____ Time needed: ____ min

Step 5: Task: _____ Time needed: ____ min

Step 6: Task: _____ Time needed: ____ min

Step 7: Task: _____ Time needed: ____ min

Step 8: Task: _____ Time needed: ____ min

Step 9: Task: _____ Time needed: ____ min

Step 10: Task: _____ Time needed: ____ min

TOTAL TIME NEEDED: _____ minutes

ADD BUFFER: + 15 minutes (because ADHD time isn't real time)

I need to wake up at: _____ **to leave by:** _____

TIP: Take a photo of this list and set it as your phone lockscreen.

TIME ESTIMATION PRACTICE

How long things ACTUALLY take (not how long you think)

For 5 days, time your morning tasks. You'll be shocked.

TASK	GUESS	DAY 1	DAY 2	DAY 3	DAY 4	DAY 5
Shower (water on to fully dressed)	___min	___min	___min	___min	___min	___min
Get dressed (picking outfit to done)	___min	___min	___min	___min	___min	___min
Eat breakfast	___min	___min	___min	___min	___min	___min
Brush teeth + face + hair	___min	___min	___min	___min	___min	___min
Pack bag / gather things	___min	___min	___min	___min	___min	___min
Find keys/phone/wallet	___min	___min	___min	___min	___min	___min
Get in car / to bus stop	___min	___min	___min	___min	___min	___min
Scroll phone (be honest)	___min	___min	___min	___min	___min	___min

TOTAL ACTUAL TIME (average): _____ minutes

INSIGHT: Most people with ADHD underestimate by 50-100%.

Use your ACTUAL times, not your optimistic guesses.

LAUNCH PAD SETUP GUIDE

A 'Launch Pad' is a designated spot by your door where EVERYTHING you need to leave the house lives. No searching. No decisions.

WHAT YOU NEED:

- A table, shelf, hook, or basket BY your exit door
- Good enough lighting to see it
- Nothing else stored there (dedicated space only)

WHAT GOES ON THE LAUNCH PAD (every night):

- ☐ Keys
- ☐ Wallet/purse
- ☐ Phone (charging there overnight is ideal)
- ☐ Bag/backpack (packed with tomorrow's needs)
- ☐ Sunglasses
- ☐ Jacket/coat (weather appropriate)
- ☐ Medications
- ☐ Lunch (or money for lunch)
- ☐ Anything specific to tomorrow: _____

MY LAUNCH PAD LOCATION: _____

THE RULE: If it leaves the house with you, it lives on the launch pad. If it comes home with you, it goes back to the launch pad. Every. Single. Time.

PRO TIP: Put a small basket/tray for small items.
Hooks for keys and bags. A charging station for devices.

CLOTHING DECISION ELIMINATOR

Getting dressed should not take 20 minutes. Here's how to fix it:

STRATEGY 1: THE CAPSULE WARDROBE

Pick 5-7 outfits that all work. Rotate through them. Done.

STRATEGY 2: THE UNIFORM METHOD

Wear basically the same thing every day (like Steve Jobs).

Nobody notices or cares. Trust me.

STRATEGY 3: OUTFIT PREP NIGHT BEFORE

Set out tomorrow's complete outfit (including underwear, socks, shoes) the night before. Decision made = morning brain off the hook.

MY WEEKLY OUTFIT PLAN:

Monday:

Tuesday:

Wednesday:

Thursday:

Friday:

Saturday:

Sunday:

WEATHER OVERRIDE: If weather changes, I wear: _____

BREAKFAST SIMPLIFICATION

ADHD breakfast rules: NO decisions, NO cooking time, NO cleanup.

TIER 1: ZERO EFFORT (grab and eat, even in the car)

- Protein bar + banana
- Overnight oats (made night before)
- Hard boiled eggs (batch prepped Sunday)
- Greek yogurt cup + granola
- Peanut butter on bread (no toasting needed)

TIER 2: LOW EFFORT (5 min or less)

- Smoothie (pre-measured bags in freezer + blend)
- Toast + avocado/peanut butter
- Cereal (yes, cereal counts as breakfast)
- Microwave oatmeal packet

TIER 3: SKIP BREAKFAST OPTION

If eating in the morning is impossible, pre-pack a mid-morning snack.

It's better than nothing and removes the morning pressure.

MY BREAKFAST ROTATION (no thinking required):

Mon/Wed/Fri: _____

Tue/Thu: _____

Weekends: _____

GROCERY LIST ADDITION (always have on hand):

_____, _____, _____, _____

30-DAY MORNING TRACKER

Days 1-3

DAY 1 Date: ___/___/___

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ___ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ___

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 2 Date: ___/___/___

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ___ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ___

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 3 Date: ___/___/___

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ___ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ___

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

30-DAY MORNING TRACKER

Days 4-6

DAY 4 Date: ___/___/___

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? ☐ Yes ☐ Mostly ☐ No

Out the door on time? ☐ Yes ☐ Late by ___ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ___

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 5 Date: ___/___/___

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? ☐ Yes ☐ Mostly ☐ No

Out the door on time? ☐ Yes ☐ Late by ___ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ___

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 6 Date: ___/___/___

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? ☐ Yes ☐ Mostly ☐ No

Out the door on time? ☐ Yes ☐ Late by ___ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ___

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

30-DAY MORNING TRACKER

Days 7-9

DAY 7 Date: ____/____/____

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ____ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ____

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 8 Date: ____/____/____

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ____ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ____

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 9 Date: ____/____/____

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ____ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ____

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

30-DAY MORNING TRACKER

Days 10-12

DAY 10 Date: ___/___/___

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ___ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ___

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 11 Date: ___/___/___

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ___ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ___

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 12 Date: ___/___/___

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ___ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ___

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

30-DAY MORNING TRACKER

Days 13-15

DAY 13 Date: ___/___/___

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ___ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ___

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 14 Date: ___/___/___

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ___ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ___

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 15 Date: ___/___/___

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ___ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ___

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

30-DAY MORNING TRACKER

Days 16-18

DAY 16 Date: ___/___/___

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ___ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ___

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 17 Date: ___/___/___

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ___ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ___

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 18 Date: ___/___/___

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ___ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ___

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

30-DAY MORNING TRACKER

Days 19-21

DAY 19 Date: ____/____/____

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ____ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ____

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 20 Date: ____/____/____

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ____ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ____

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 21 Date: ____/____/____

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ____ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ____

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

30-DAY MORNING TRACKER

Days 22-24

DAY 22 Date: ___/___/___

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ___ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ___

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 23 Date: ___/___/___

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ___ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ___

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 24 Date: ___/___/___

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ___ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ___

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

30-DAY MORNING TRACKER

Days 25-27

DAY 25 Date: ____/____/____

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ____ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ____

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 26 Date: ____/____/____

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ____ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ____

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 27 Date: ____/____/____

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ____ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ____

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

30-DAY MORNING TRACKER

Days 28-30

DAY 28 Date: ____/____/____

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ____ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ____

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 29 Date: ____/____/____

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ____ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ____

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

DAY 30 Date: ____/____/____

Wake time (alarm): _____ Wake time (actual): _____

Routine completed? [] Yes [] Mostly [] No

Out the door on time? [] Yes [] Late by ____ min

Mood leaving house: 1-5 (1=stressed 5=calm): ____

What worked: _____

What didn't: _____

EVENING PREP CHECKLIST

Set Up Tomorrow Tonight (Your Morning Self Will Thank You)

Do this checklist every evening. It takes 10-15 minutes and saves your morning self 30+ minutes of chaos.

- ☐ Set out tomorrow's outfit (full outfit including shoes)
- ☐ Pack bag/backpack with everything needed tomorrow
- ☐ Place keys/wallet/phone on launch pad
- ☐ Check calendar - any special items needed?
- ☐ Pack lunch or set out lunch money
- ☐ Charge all devices
- ☐ Set alarm(s) - at least 2 alarms
- ☐ Quick kitchen reset (so morning you doesn't face a mess)
- ☐ Review tomorrow's schedule (reduce morning surprises)
- ☐ Lay out medications/vitamins by water glass
- ☐ Note anything special for morning: _____

EVENING PREP TIME: I'll do this at ____:____ pm every night.

REMINDER: Set a phone alarm for your evening prep time!

TROUBLESHOOTING COMMON MORNING FAILS

PROBLEM: Can't get out of bed (hit snooze 10 times)

- Put alarm across room / in bathroom
- Use alarmy app (requires photo/math to turn off)
- Set coffee maker auto-start (smell motivates)

PROBLEM: Get sucked into phone immediately

- Phone stays on launch pad, not bedside
- No social media until after anchor 2
- Use app blocker until 9am

PROBLEM: Can't find things (keys, shoes, papers)

- Everything has ONE home. Always.
- Launch pad system (page 7)
- Tile/AirTag on keys and wallet

PROBLEM: Take too long in shower

- Set waterproof timer for 7 minutes
- Shower at night instead (remove from morning)
- Use shower routine: hair, face, body, done

PROBLEM: Hyperfocus on random thing

- Visual timer in every room (Time Timer brand)
- 'This can wait' sticky note on mirror
- Body double: morning phone call with friend

PROBLEM: Run out of time for breakfast

- Grab-and-go options ONLY (see page 9)
- Eat at work/school instead
- Pre-made smoothie in fridge

KIDS MORNING ROUTINE

If you have ADHD kids who also struggle with mornings

ADHD often runs in families. If your child also has morning chaos:

VISUAL SCHEDULE (use pictures for younger kids):

1. Wake up + get out of bed
2. Use bathroom
3. Get dressed (outfit laid out night before)
4. Eat breakfast (choice of 2 options only)
5. Brush teeth
6. Grab backpack (packed night before)
7. Shoes on + out the door

TIPS FOR ADHD KIDS' MORNINGS:

- Use a visual timer they can see counting down
- 'Beat the timer' makes it a game (dopamine!)
- Same order every single day (no variety)
- Reduce decisions to 0 (lay everything out)
- Music playlist that times the routine
- Natural consequences > yelling (miss bus = walk)

MY CHILD'S MORNING ROUTINE:

Step 1: _____ (___ min)

Step 2: _____ (___ min)

Step 3: _____ (___ min)

Step 4: _____ (___ min)

Step 5: _____ (___ min)

Step 6: _____ (___ min)

Total time needed: _____ min

Must wake by: _____

PARTNER COMMUNICATION

Talking to your partner/household about your needs

Mornings can create household tension. Here's how to talk about it:

WHAT TO EXPLAIN TO YOUR PARTNER:

'My brain works differently in the morning. It's not laziness or disrespect. I need external supports because my internal clock and executive function are impaired before I'm fully awake.'

WHAT HELPS (share this list with them):

- Don't ask me complex questions before [time]
- If I seem stuck/zoned out, a gentle physical cue helps
- Don't rearrange my launch pad or morning setup
- Specific, brief reminders are helpful (not nagging)
- Morning is not the time for hard conversations

WHAT I NEED FROM MY PARTNER/HOUSEHOLD:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

WHAT I CAN OFFER IN RETURN:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

OUR MORNING AGREEMENT:

We agree that mornings will work like this: _____

Signed: _____ & _____ Date: _____